

Finding Appeal

Creative Careers in Animation, Computer Graphics, and Interactive Techniques

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ABSTRACT

Industry panelists share perspectives and insights for students and educators who are considering careers in animation, computer graphics, and interactive techniques. Creative industries continue to transform as a result of the global pandemic. Streaming media platforms, virtual production systems, faster network communications, and advances in machine learning are radically transforming creative industries and cultural production. Simultaneously, transformed workplace cultures and new technologies make room for alternative career paths, presenting a variety of opportunities and unforeseen challenges. Individual representatives discuss the general and specific state of affairs within their own industries, and provide insight into changing employment paradigms. Discussion includes advice for educators to help prepare students for changing workplace cultures, as well as the preparation, training, and personal attributes needed to enter related career fields, or make professional career transitions. Panelists consider what qualities make for desirable applicants in their respective fields, and elaborate upon changes in the transition from school to work resulting from the global pandemic. Represented industry segments include animation and VFX, virtual production, interactive design, and immersive themed entertainment. Questions considered include how pedagogy can help prepare and empower students for successful creative careers; what entry-level applicants should have (and should not have) on resumes, portfolios, and demo reels; and what can creative talents do to proactively acquire requisite credentials. Discussion will expose fresh outlooks on the futures of creative fields in animation, computer graphics, and interactive techniques

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Arts and humanities; Education; • **Social and professional topics** → Professional topics.

KEYWORDS

Education, Creative Careers, Entry-level Employment, Demo Reels

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1 PANELISTS

Johannes DeYoung (moderator) is an artist and educator who works at the intersection of computational and material processes. He is appointed Associate Professor of Electronic and Time-Based Media at Carnegie Mellon University School of Art in Pittsburgh, PA. His work has been exhibited internationally in major galleries and museums in countries such as Spain, Taiwan, Germany, USA, Canada, Ireland, and Australia, as well as being featured in The New York Times, The New York Post, The Huffington Post, and Dossier Journal. He has lectured on his work at institutions and venues such as Yale University School of Art; Pennsylvania Academy of Fine Arts; Tyler School of Art at Temple University; Landmark Arts Gallery at Texas Tech University School of Art; Lyme Academy College of Fine Arts; the Society for Animation Studies; MODE Summit; the IEEE Games, Entertainment, and Media conference; CINAN-IMA International Animated Film Festival; and the University Film and Video Association. From 2008–2018, he was appointed Senior Critic at Yale University School of Art and founding Director of the Center for Collaborative Arts and Media. He received his MFA from the Cranbrook Academy of Art in Bloomfield Hills, MI.

Sahar Kausar is a Character Technical Director for Walt Disney Animation Studios based in Los Angeles, California with her specialties encompassing cloth tailoring, hair grooming, and technical animation. Her recent credits have included *Encanto*, *Strange World*, *Baymax!*, *Zootopia+*, and the *Short Circuit: Reflect*. Prior to joining the Studios, Sahar worked as an engineer for Walt Disney Imagineering where she brought animatronics to life. Her major portfolio contributions were to Tokyo Disneyland's *Enchanted Tale of Beauty and the Beast*, Hong Kong Disneyland's *World of Frozen*, Shanghai Disneyland's *Zootopia*, USA Disneyland's *Marvel Campus*, and both *Star Wars: Galaxy's Edge* USA locations. Sahar passionately fuses art and engineering to create immersive experiences, utilizing storytelling to spark joy worldwide.

Cat Gulácsy is a Senior Talent Acquisition Specialist focusing on post-production, interactivity and design. Through her company,

Calling All Talent LLC, Cat draws upon more than a decade of experience in talent acquisition to advise, source and consult for many internationally recognized studios. Cat's previous collaborations and professional credits include work with Crafty Apes VFX, Framestore, Method Studios, Nickelodeon, Silver Spoon Animation, Zoic Studios, and The Mill. Cat is a passionate advocate for inclusion, education and mentorship. She is an adjunct professor at the School of Visual Arts, where she teaches the Business of Being an Artist. She also teaches Digital Animation & VFX Portfolio Development at Brooklyn College, and Professional Practices at Pratt Institute. Cat serves as Co-Chair of ACCESS:VFX New York Chapter, and she is Industry Outreach Advisor for The Animation Project Inc., a program to increase access to education and promote new talent in animation.

Katie Tender is a Turnover Artist and software developer on the Avatar sequels, where she defines, develops, and performs virtual

production workflows. In December 2022, she received her first film credit for work on "Avatar: The Way of Water". She is passionate about using code to remove constraints on the creative possibilities of CG technologies. Prior to joining the Avatar productions, she worked as an Animation Designer at the Carnegie Mellon Robotics Institute. She graduated from Carnegie Mellon University in May 2020 with a BFA in Electronic and Time-Based Media with a minor in Animation and Special Effects.

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